

Music 190gew: Music in Islamic Contexts
Professor Richard K. Wolf

Office: 031 Memorial Hall

Meets: Thursdays 1-3, Room 4, Music Building

Course Overview:

This class provides an approach to a set of questions fundamental to understanding music in any social-cultural setting: What galvanizes individuals to make sound and to move physically with their voices, instruments, and bodies? What motivates others to join in or censure them? What norms govern the emotionality of performance and how do individuals and groups manipulate those norms? Why are some kinds of sound and movement regarded as “music” and “dance” and others not? Why would the status of sound as “music” or “art” be of cultural concern?

Such broad questions gain traction in contexts that present the possibility for strongly opposed points of view. Nowhere are such views set in such striking relief as in some parts of the so-called Muslim world today. This course focuses on the arts of sound practiced by Muslims in India, Pakistan, and Iran, and on procedures of recitation that grow from pre-Islamic roots among Arabic-speaking peoples. The purposes are two-fold: one is to understand from a musically informed perspective a set of interrelated musical practices that cut across South and West Asia. The second is to understand how different ideologies, philosophies, and texts—associated with Islam locally, nationally, and internationally—shape local understandings and constructions of sound.

Throughout the course we will attempt to strike a balance between understanding music viscerally (as listeners and performers) and understanding what is at stake for different constituencies of Muslims who encounter and comment upon the genres we study. The course proceeds from a two-week introduction of basic concepts to a practical engagement with the art music of Iran. Throughout the semester, enrollees will have the opportunity to build on their knowledge by learning Persian music with a local Iranian musician and to practice on instruments owned by the Music Department. This effort will assist students in recognizing some of the similar musical procedures involved in Quranic recitation and South Asian raga-based singing, while also providing a basis for hearing important distinctions among these genres.

After the introductory weeks, the class continues with a deeper look at concepts of music in Islam by examining Quranic chant and prominent debates about music in the history of Islam. Students will discover the importance of the “word” in Islamic culture; they’ll study how pronunciation and meter (important too in pre-Islamic Arabic) serve as both resources and constraints in vocal and instrumental performances. The changing relationships of music to text, and the moral implications of such relationships, deepen as subjects of investigation in each subsequent unit.

The final two parts of the course introduce prominent genres in South and West Asia associated with Sufism and Shi‘ism. Students will learn that there are many kinds of Sufism and approaches to Shi‘ism, and that these differences sometimes pertain to matters of musical performance. In addition to building on their knowledge of technical themes of text and doctrine, students will be urged to contemplate how religious belief systems channel and classify emotion. The strong cultural, religious, and often very local context for music-making shapes the ways in which Muslims involved in music report their reactions to music and their reasons for participating in its performance. Thinking about music and emotion in these ways will lead the class back to some of the initial questions about motivations for music-making posed at the beginning of the course.

The content of classes will include lectures, discussions, live musical demonstrations and careful review of audio-visual materials. Hands-on Persian music instruction will be offered at times to be arranged outside the usual Thursday time-slot.

Requirements:

Students are expected to attend every class session on time and complete reading, writing, and listening assignments on time. Hands-on Persian music lessons are not required for the purposes of grading, but if you commit to learning, you are expected to practice and attend tutorial sessions.

Students will report on readings and progress on term projects throughout the semester. Assignments include weekly reading, video, listening, and written reports (300 words per week); three listening and short-answer quizzes (15 minutes in class) and one written project 15 pages (~6,000 words). Students may select from a broad spectrum of final paper topics, ranging from ethnographic or historical studies of specific communities to analyses of particular musical repertoires. Graduate students will be expected to do additional work—to be arranged individually.

Prerequisites

There are no specific course prerequisites. It is assumed that students will contribute to the classroom experience based on different kinds of preparation. Some will bring strong musical training; others may have experience as students or practitioners of religion; and others may possess expertise in the languages of Persian, Arabic, or Urdu.

Grading:

Attendance, participation: 25%

Written Assignments: 30%

Listening and short-answer quizzes (3 x 5%): 15%

Final Project: 30%

Supplementary Materials: The pages for some weeks contain subpages entitled "supplementary." These may include recorded examples tied to the weekly reading (the examples being of subordinate concern to the week's topic) as well as additional related reading and video examples. These are generally for your own exploration only and not required. If materials currently labeled supplementary become required, it will be so noted in class and on the website. It is recommended that you at least cast a glance at what is in the supplementary slot each week. The supplementary page will also be used to store copies of some of the handouts from class; so if you lose your hard copy, check there first.

Academic Integrity: Homework assignments, quizzes and exams must be completed individually unless it is explicitly stated otherwise. All written work must be original and sources must receive full citations for quotes or paraphrases. Work submitted for this course should not be submitted in any form for another course without written permission from both professors.

Accommodations for students with disabilities: Students needing academic adjustments or accommodations because of a documented disability must present their Faculty Letter from the Accessible Education Office (AEO) and speak with the professor by the end of the second week of the term. Failure to do so may result in the professor's inability to respond in a timely manner. All discussions will remain confidential, although Faculty members are invited to contact AEO to discuss appropriate implementation.

General Education: Note: This course, when taken for a letter grade, meets the General Education requirement for Culture and Belief or Aesthetic and Interpretive Understanding, but not both.

Schedule:

PART I: INTRODUCTION

9/19 Class 1: Introduction: Music and Musical Instruments of the Islamic World

9/26 Class 2: Islam and Music: Some common themes

Blum, S. 2002. "Hearing the music of the Middle East." In *The Middle East. The Garland Encyclopedia of World Music* v.6, pp. 3-14, ed. Danielson et al. New York: Routledge.

Eaton, R. 2000. Excerpt from "Islamic history as world history." In *Essays on Islam and Indian history*, pp. 13-37. New Delhi: Oxford University Press.

Marcus, S. 2002. "The Muslim call to prayer." In *The Middle East. The Garland Encyclopedia of World Music* v.6, pp. 153-55, ed. Danielson et al. New York: Routledge.

Pickthall, M. M. 1977. "Introduction." In *The meaning of the glorious Qur'an. Text and explanatory translation*, pp. iv-xvii. Mecca: Muslim World League.

Supplemental Reading: Denny, W. 1985. "Music and musicians in Islamic art" *Asian Music* 17(1): 37-65

Required Listening:

Calls to prayer: 1) Moulavi Al Hafil A. R. Bathurudeen, Ootacamund, Tamil Nadu, India

Image of A. R. Bathurudeen

2) Azan in Tehran, Iran (probably 2002, unidentified reciter)

Student Report: Sakata, H.L. 1983. *Music in the Mind*. Kent: Kent State University Press

PART II: A PRACTICAL INTRODUCTION TO THE ART MUSIC OF IRAN

We develop musical tools for understanding Iranian music that are useful for listening to many kinds of artful performances using the voice and musical instruments in the Muslim world

10/3 Class 3: The Radif and Improvisation in Iranian music

Blum, S. 2002. "Iran: An introduction." In *The Middle East. The Garland Encyclopedia of World Music* v.6, pp. 823-38, ed. Danielson et al. New York: Routledge.

*Supplemental listening: "Track 26: Gharībī, lyric song of Khorasan province, Iran," recorded by S. Blum in Mashhad, Iran, 1969.

"Track 27: Persian narrative song sung by an ironsmith," recorded by S. Blum in Mashhad, 1969.

Caton, M. "Performance practice in Iran: Radif and Improvisation." In *The Middle East. The Garland Encyclopedia of World Music* v.6, pp. 129-143, ed. Danielson et al. New York: Routledge.

* Required Listening: "Track 28: Persian classical music: Masnavi in the dastgāh of māhur."

Varzi, M. 1988. Performer-audience relationships in the bazm. In Cultural parameters of Iranian musical expression. Edited by Margaret Caton and Neil Siegel.

Use the following to become familiar with the darāmad section of Bayāt-e Tork; compare to listening last week

Farhat, H. 1990 " Dastgāh-e Bayāt-e Tork." In The Dastgāh concept in Persian music, pp. 43-6; 134-5. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Massoudieh, M. 1997. " Āvāz-e Bayāt-e Tork, darāmad-e-avval and dowwom." In The vocal radif of traditional Iranian music according to the version of Mahmoud Karimi: Transcription and analyses, pp. 33-34. Tehran: Iranian Music Association.

Required Listening: Karimi, M. " Āvāz-e Bayāt-e Tork, darāmad-e-avval and dowwom"

Nazeri, Shahram. Ensemble improvisation in Bayāt-e Tork.

See also (follow up from Class 2): "Bāmdādān ke tafāwut": notation and recording

10/10 Class 4: Sections of the Radif: The Dastgāh of Māhur

Farhat, H. 1990. " Musical concepts and terminology." In The Dastgāh concept in Persian music, pp. 19-26. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Farhat, H. 1990. " Dastgāh-e Māhur." In The Dastgāh concept in Persian music, pp. 89-99. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Traditional Persian Art Music 363-452, "Māhur" (follow notation with recording) (selected gushehs) (whole radif)

Listening: (focus on the gushehs discussed in class) Follow link to list of clickable gushehs for listening

Traditional persian art music, CD 4: Māhur (On Reserve at the Music Library; same as online above).

Supplemental Reading: Nettl, B. 1992. Chapter 4: "Four modern radifs of mahur." In The radif of Persian music, pp 77-92 (in hard copy, or pp. 100-118 in pdf). Champaign: Elephant and Cat.

Supplemental Listening and Notation: Selections from Māhur as performed by Mahmoud Karim

Supplemental Chart: Characteristic Ranges of a Few Gushehs in Māhur

PART III: CONCEPTS OF "RECITATION" AND "MUSIC" IN ISLAM

The notion of "music" in many parts of the Muslim world is highly fraught. Many styles of using the voice and instruments are considered to be ways of reciting and not ways of performing music.

10/17 Class 5: The Qur'ān and the Concept of Recitation

Pickthall, M. M. 1977. " Surah 1: The opening." In The meaning of the glorious Qur'an. Text and explanatory translation, pp. 1-2. Mecca: Muslim World League. (see also 2:137, 9:61-2; 18:11, 19:98, 21:45, cited in al-Faruqi 1987)

Graham, W. 1987. " 'Arabic reciting': Qur'an as spoken book." In *Beyond the written word: Oral aspects of scripture in the history of religion*, 88-92; 96-104. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

al Faruqi, Lois Ibsen. 1987. " The cantillation of the Qur'ān." *Asian Music* 19(1): 2-21

Supplemental Reading: Davies, K. N. 2002. " The Qur'ān recited." In *The Middle East. The Garland Encyclopedia of World Music v.6*, 157-63, ed. Danielson et al. New York: Routledge.

Required Listening/Viewing: Video: Word power in Islamic art. *Archive of World Music V* 11036

Quranic recitation examples

Student Report: Nelson, Kristina. 1985. *The art of reciting the Qur'ān*. Austin: University of Texas Press. (Loeb Music, Seeger Room: Mus 199.10.77)

10/24 Class 6: Debates on music in Islam

QUIZ 1

Hujwiri. 1996. *Selections from The Kashf Al-Mahjub: The oldest Persian treatise on Sufism*, pp. v-xi; 393-420. Translated by R. Nicholson. Lahore: Sang-e-Meel Publications.

Faruqi, L. " The sound arts or music." In *Islam and Art*, 179-209. Islamabad: National Hijra Council.

Nasr, S. 1997. " Islam and Music: The Legal and Spiritual Dimensions." In *Enchanting Powers: Music in the world's religions*, pp. 219-34, ed. By L. Sullivan. Cambridge: Harvard University Press.

Gribetz, A. 1991. " The Samā' controversy: Sufi vs. legalist." *Studia Islamica* 74:43-61

Student report/supplemental reading: Al-Ghazzali. 1901-1902. *Emotional religion in Islam as affected by Music and Singing. Being a translation of a Book of of al-Ghazzali with analysis, annotation and appendices*. By Duncan B. MacDonald. *Journal of the Royal Asiatic Society*.

PART IV: MUSIC IN SUFISM

Although there is no single kind of "Sufi" or "Shi'i" music or recitation, many local participants relate the sound of performance to the religious context of performance. Parts IV and V, which explore such relationships, also provide an introduction to the raga and tala system of North Indian and Pakistani music.

10/31 Class 7: Sufism and Qawwali

Qureshi, R. 1972. " Indo-Muslim religious music: An overview." *Asian Music* 3(2): 15-22.

Ernst, C. 2000. " What is Sufism?" In *The Shambhala guide to Sufism*, pp. 1-31. Boston: Shambhala South Asia Editions.

Eaton, R. 1974. " Sufi folk literature and the expansion of Indian Islam." *History of Religions* 14(2): 117-27.

Qureshi, R. 1995. " What is Qawwali," pp. 1-5; " The Qawwali repertoire," pp. 19-45; " The proper procedure for Qawwali," pp. 115-128; " Building the performance" pp. 193-207. In *Sufi Music in India and Pakistan: Sound, context and meaning in Qawwali*. Reprint edition with new preface and compact disc. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

*Required listening: CD tr. 1: " The qaul: Man Kunto Maula"; CD tr. 3 " Chashm-e maste-'ajabe" ;

Required Listening/Viewing: Video: "I am a Sufi, I am a Muslim" AWM V 11294

Supplemental Reading: Remaining chapters of Qureshi 1995.

Student report: Abbas, S. 2002. The female voice in Sufi ritual. Austin: University of Texas Press.

11/7 Class 8: Qawwali and Mystical Themes

Asani, A. 1986. " Music and dance in the work of Jalal Al-din Rumi" Islamic Culture 60(2): 41-55.

Qureshi, R. 1986. " The Background." In Sufi Music in India and Pakistan, pp. 79-102.

Required Listening/Viewing: Qawwali video: Badar Ali Khan and party performing Man Kunto Maula

Student Report: Ernst, C. 1992. Eternal Garden: Mysticism, History, and Politics at a South Asian Sufi Center. Albany: State University of New York Press. (Widener: WID-LC BP189.7.C49 E76 1992)

Werbner, P. and H. Basu, eds. 1998. Embodying charisma. London: Routledge.

11/14 Class 9: Case study from a Sufi Shrine

Wolf presentation: "The poetics of Sufi Practice."

Recommended Viewing: 'Urs of Madho Lal Husain (streamed version; formerly available through "videos" folder)

Van Der Veer, P. 1992. Playing or praying: A Sufi saint's day in Surat. Journal of Asian Studies 51(3): 545-64.

Kugle, S. 2000. Haqiqat al-Fuqara: Poetic biography of "Madho Lal" Hussayn (Persian). In Same sex love in India: Readings from literature and history, 145-56, ed. R. Vanita and S. Kidwai. NY: St. Martin's Press.

Malik, F. M. 1997. Shah Husain and the Malamatiya Sufi tradition. Pakistan Journal of History and Culture 18(1): 77-90.

Student Report: Ewing, K. 1997. Arguing sainthood: Modernity, psychoanalysis, and Islam. Durham: Duke University Press.

PART V: MUSIC IN SHI'ISM

11/21 Class 10: The performance of Shi'i Islam

Pinault, D. 1992. " Shiism: An overview" and "Essentials of Islam common to the Shiite and Sunni traditions." In The Shiites: Ritual and popular piety in a Muslim community, pp. 3-26. New York: St. Martin's Press.

Mottahedeh, R. The Mantle of the Prophet: Religion and politics in Iran, pp. 134-185. Oxford: One World

Chelkowski, Peter. 1979. " Ta'ziyeh: Indigenous Avant-Garde Theatre of Iran." In Ta'ziyeh: Ritual and Drama in Iran. New York: NYU Press, pp. 1-11

Supplemental: Chelkowski, Peter. 1991. " Popular Entertainment, media and social change in Twentieth-Century Iran." *The CambridgeHistory of Iran* v. 7. 765-814

In class: Movie: Le Lion de Dieu

Explanatory text (French and English)

11/28 Class 11: Ta'ziyeh and Rowzeh

Guest: Professor Stephen Blum

Blum, S. 1996. " Musical questions and answers in Iranian Xorasan." *EM: Annuari degli Accademia Nazionale di Santa Cecilia* 4: 145-63.

Shahidi, A. 1979. " Literary and musical developments in the Ta'ziyeh." In *Ta'ziyeh: Ritual and Drama in Iran*, pp. 40-60. New York: NYU Press.

12/5 Class 12: Shiah majlis in India

Qureshi, R. 1981. " Islamic music in an Indian environment: The Shia majlis." *Ethnomusicology* 25(1): 41-71.

Listening/Viewing: Majlis genres examples (click here for list of examples as pdf with diacritics)

Muharram videos (TBA)

Student Report: Reza, R. 1994. *The feuding families of village Gangauli*. Tr. G. Wright. New Delhi: Viking.

Dunham, M. 1997. *Jarigan: Muslim Epic Songs of Bangladesh*. Dhaka: The University Press Limited.

12/12 Class 13: Drumming and emotion in Shi'ism

Pinault, David. 1992. " Lamentation rituals." In *The Shiites*, pp. 99-114. New York: St. Martin's Press.

Wolf, R. " Embodiment and Ambivalence: Emotion in South Asian Muharram Drumming." *Yearbook for Traditional Music* 32: 81-116.

Reckford, T. 1986. " The role of religious chant in the definition of the Iranian aesthetic." In *Cultural parameters of Iranian musical expression*. Edited by Margaret Caton and Neil Siegel.

Student Report: Pinault, D. 2001. *The horse of Karbala: Muslim devotional life in India*. New York: Palgrave

Korom, F. 2003. *Hosay Trinidad*. Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press.

QUIZ 2

12/19 Class 14: Student Presentations